

type of aileron – that is, moving a special control surface that was part of the wing, rather than twisting the whole wing. Only the Voisin biplane still flew completely flat.

All the flying machines suffered from unreliable engines, which were to be a concern of aviators for years to come. Even here, however, progress was afoot. The Henri Farman III sported a Gnome rotary engine, designed and manufactured by the Séguin brothers. Whereas in a radial or in-line engine the cylinders would be fixed around a rotating crankshaft, in the rotary engine the cylinders span around with the propeller. The Gnome created some fearsome gyroscopic effects, making the airplane relatively difficult to control, as well as giving off nauseous castor-oil fumes and alarming spurts of flaming oil. But it generated a lot of power for its weight, and was to play a leading part in aviation until well into World War I.

The Reims aviation week was almost ruined by the weather which, as during the Channel-crossing bids, was singularly inclement for the summer season. Torrential rain and strong winds kept the aircraft grounded for most of the first day, in front of a damp and restive crowd. But later on, the weather cleared and Wright biplanes piloted by the Comte de Lambert, Eugène Lefebvre, and Paul Tissandier were catapulted into the air, amazing the crowd as they changed altitude in easy swoops, and banked around the pylons

“Flying machines are no longer toys and dreams, they are an established fact.”

DAVID LLOYD GEORGE
BRITISH POLITICIAN, AT REIMS, 1909

would emerge from his hangar, would only increase the expectation of the spectators and the fascination of the spectacle.

Thrills and spills

There was no lack of thrills and spills. Few of the pilots at Reims had yet accumulated much experience in the air, and some were virtual novices. Some crashes were a result of ill-judged maneuvers – too steep a climb, too tight a turn – while many others were a consequence of air turbulence, especially later in the week when the weather heated up. Glenn Curtiss admitted to a surprise that must have been felt by other pilots: “I had not then become accustomed to the feeling an aviator gets when the machine takes a sudden drop.”

True to form, the accident-prone Blériot experienced the most serious incident, when his Type XII monoplane burst into flames because of a ruptured fuel line. Yet no one was seriously injured and the general impression was that flying machines had proved their worthiness. About 120 flights were made in the week, almost three-quarters of them covering more than 3 miles (5km).

The high points of the meeting for spectators were the victories in the three key competitions,

A RISKY BUSINESS

There was no lack of action and drama at Reims. At times the ground was littered with the wreckage of airplanes – the result of poorly judged maneuvers and difficult flying conditions.

